

As a child growing up in Bhiwani, boxing was all around her. The town itself is one of the nurseries for the sport in India — six of the seven gold medals won by Indian boxers in Glasgow were claimed by boxers who grew up in and around this region of Haryana. The sport was even closer to Jaismine. Both her uncles — Parvinder Singh and Sandeep Singh — were international boxers. There is also a connection to Captain Hawa Singh, the legendary two-time Asian Games champion, through her uncle Sandeep's wife.

One of Jaismine's earliest childhood memories involves the Commonwealth Games. "I think I would have been around five years old when I saw Parvinder Chacha compete at the 2006 Commonwealth Games." Parvinder competed in the men's middleweight division, winning his opening bout against Charles E. Njock of Cameroon before going down to Scotland's Craig McEwan. "Even from a very young age I always wanted to be a boxer," Jaismine recalls.

Not everyone in the family was as keen. "I was in the eighth grade when I first asked my mother if I could learn from my uncles. She kept saying she would ask later. She simply hoped I would outgrow it," Jaismine recalls.

Two years later, when Jaismine's mother did speak to Parvinder, he himself tried to stop her. "When Jaismine's mother came and asked whether she could train with us, I initially tried to discourage her," says her uncle Sandeep. "In our time boxing was really hard. There wasn't a lot of support. You had to be able to tolerate a lot of hardship. I didn't want another from my family to go through that," he says.

There was another reason — Jaismine was good at school. "She was pretty good in studies so I said why would an educated smart girl want to learn boxing. She would get

beaten up," Sandeep says.

Finally, Jaismine's persistence wore her uncles down and they agreed to train her at the family home. What began as an attempt to humour a determined teenager soon became something else. "I actually wanted her to pick up a sport which wasn't as hard on the body like shooting," Parvinder says.

"But I realised very early on that she had the natural gift to be a boxer. She had really long arms — they went down to her knees. For the average person, it goes down to the mid-thigh. Captain Hawa Singh had the same physique. She also had a long neck. I told her mother she was born to be a boxer," he recalls.

There was still one obstacle — the family patriarch.

Jaismine's oldest grand uncle Chandra Bhan had been a well-known wrestler but was conservative in his thinking. Boxing was one thing for the men in the family. For a girl, it was something else.

"In our family girls aren't fighters. They can study and get married but they don't learn sports," he told Sandeep.

Change was in the air, though. PV Sindhu and Sakshi Malik had just won medals at the 2016 Rio Olympics. "I came up to him with the newspaper cutting of that Olympic medal and said 'tau, look, a girl from Haryana has now won an Olympic medal. Surely one of our own daughters can do this also. Finally he agreed,'" Sandeep says.

A few weeks later, Parvinder and Sandeep took Jaismine to the police training academy at Madhuban, Haryana. There were a few girls training there and, just to test Jaismine's level, her uncles put her into a sparring session against a boxer who had already been training for more than a year. Jaismine won comfortably.

It happened again in her early competitions. At the Haryana Khel Mahakumbh in December 2018, she faced Parveen Hooda. Hooda, who incidentally was also part of the Indian contingent that competed at Glasgow, was the more experienced boxer, and Parvinder told the judges that he knew she was senior but wanted Jaismine to be treated fairly.

Hooda won, but the 3-2 scoreline was far closer than many would have anticipated. Two months later, Jaismine fought Manisha Moun — a World Championships quarterfinalist — in the final of the All India University competition in Udaipur. This time there was no narrow defeat. Jaismine won convincingly.

As her talent continued to shine, Jaismine continued to make her way in the national system. By 2022, she was a regular in the squad — winning a bronze at the 2022 Commonwealth Games in Birmingham. For all her success, though, something was still lacking.

It would come strangely enough at one of the lowest points of her career.

